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growth. India's young and mobile demographics with an average age of 29—in fact the next 2 billion people in the world will come from South Asia and nine African countries—and easy internal mobility have allowed labour needs through the country to be met by workers from Bihar and the East to prevent a rise in wages.

So, yes, this will be India's de-

cade; but can it be India's century? Most of India is not satisfied with its living condition. Currently, three Indias co-exist based on purchasing power parity per capita: 50 million Europeans, 450 million Indonesians, and 950 million Sub-Saharan Africans. For this to be India's century, it needs to improve the lives of the 950 million Indians living in quiet desperation.

This requires a fix in foundational elements. Water access, basic education, primary health, and adult skilling. In addition, in today's world, no country is safe without better defence and technology.

India's current water consumption stands at 1,385 m³ per capita, a third of the global average and below that of low-income countries. Many parts of India are water starved. We need to act to conserve water by changing our pricing for water and power. We need to also conserve rainwater in cities and increase agricultural land under irrigation.

Malnutrition, poor access to primary health, and poor primary schools stunt our labour force productivity. By illustration, a 42-storey building takes 10 months to complete in China and four years in India, because of both bureaucratic interference and poor-quality labour. We need to use technology to improve our health and education outcomes and upgrade the existing labour stock through a massive skilling effort to truly make our advantaged demographics a dividend.

Trump's actions after his victory are reminiscent of the bygone colonial age. 'I want Greenland, Panama, Gaza, and Canada is my 51st state!' The world is back to "might is right" and so India needs to improve its military strength. It must also work hard to ensure that it does not get shut out from the most advanced technologies shaping the future (Generative AI, quantum computing, biotechnology and others).

As late 19th century and early 20th century leader of the Democratic Party in the US, William Jennings Bryan, said: "Destiny is no of matter of chance, it is a matter of choice. It is not a thing to be waited for, it is a thing to be achieved." If we want to make this our century, we must work hard to make it happen. **BT**

Views are personal